

The Reunion

Kira's chest rose and fell in an even rhythm. The myriad machines monitoring her were an enigma to Elyssa; not too long ago, she could likely have figured out what each of them did, but now, she just felt too drained. There was a fog in her mind, and all she could see through it was her wife's unconscious face. Elyssa sat on the edge of the bed and took the elf's hand in her own. *Kira is strong*, she thought to herself.

"I'm sure that *Amme* will pull through this, Mama." Aya's voice pierced through the fog, a lighthouse in the night. Elyssa couldn't help but look over and smile at their daughter. Despite not being able to age like a normal person, she seemed older than she had the last time they'd been together. The last time... how long had it been since they'd all been together?

"I know; you're right. She'll pull through this. She's strong—something that she seems to have passed to you." Aya awkwardly turned her gaze to the ground; she probably didn't know how to respond.

"I'm not as strong as I would like. If not for my friends, I would have been unable to either find or rescue you. I owe them; they've helped me through so many adventures and saved my life countless times. They're almost like..." Aya's voice trailed off, but Elyssa understood.

"Like a second family. I'm glad to see you've made such good friends, Aya. I know you didn't get a chance to really have many, growing up the way you did." Elyssa paused for a second, thinking back to her interactions with the Changeling, the Hadozee, and the Asrian. "They seem... nice. What kinds of adventures have you been on with them?"

Aya's eyes lit up—perhaps Elyssa was just glad for a distraction from Kira's condition, but Aya seemed excited to share. Aya began to tell the story of her enlistment on the crew of someone named Charlie to pay off a debt she'd accrued on the Rock, and how it led her to meet everyone. She talked about competing in the arena on Bral with Miji and going shopping with Nylos. She described her journeys throughout the universe, from discovering various portals to other planes of existence to climbing the Mezo tree with Miji and Nylos. She had a *lot* of interesting things to say about finally meeting her Uncle Tod—Elyssa had to laugh about that. She'd never seen that side of Aya, but she could understand her reaction from what Kira had told her of Tod. Aya also described meeting Soluna and learning about the Asrian culture, and how she even got to travel to the planet where Kira and her crew traveled 60 years ago. She then described how they'd encountered the Starcutter and commandeered it, and how they were now using it as their base in their fight against the Clockwork Horrors. Once Aya had finished with all her stories, Elyssa couldn't help but feel proud of her daughter.

"My goodness, you've been busy! It sounds like you've been through a lot." Elyssa looked at her daughter, eyeing her up and down, before her eyes came to rest on her feet. "I do have a... small question, though."

Aya tilted her head quizzically. "Yes?"

“Well, I was just wondering what happened to your foot?” Aya’s left leg, from about her mid-calf down, was covered in a rather hastily-made metallic boot, fastened directly to her leg via several bolts.

“Oh.” Aya stared at the boot. “In the tower... the night the Horrors came. When they captured you, I tried to save you. One of the Horrors—the big one leading the charge. It took advantage of that and smashed me into the floor while I wasn’t looking. It snapped my leg almost all the way off and left me in a rough state, before another Horror I couldn’t see took me out.” Aya paused for a moment to collect herself, then continued. “When I woke up, I had almost no memories; at least, none about me... or my family. I couldn’t move very well with only one functional leg, so I took some scrap and tried to piece myself back together. It’s a bit stiff, compared to my other leg, but I’m used to it by now. I’ve never really felt the need to go back and improve it.” Elyssa looked at her daughter, tears in her eyes. She hopped off the bed and rushed over to Aya, pulling her into the tightest hug she could manage.

“I’m so sorry, Aya. You should never have had to deal with any of that. If you’d like, once all this is over, *Amme* and I could try to help you fix up your leg so you can move normally again. A simple little family project to help put our family back together again, right? Would you like that?”

Aya, still wrapped in Elyssa’s arms, nodded her head. Truthfully, she didn’t care about her leg; she hadn’t even thought about it since the days before she made it to Bral with Dave. But it would be nice to spend some time with her family.

Aya pulled back some from her mother. She seemed to have something she wanted to say, but she was hesitating.

“Aya?” Elyssa gave her daughter a little space. “What is it, sweetie?”

“Back when I... woke up. Even though I did not remember our family, I felt... lonely. And then I saw something, something that felt like family, and I... felt like I needed to do it. I spent weeks, making him... I...” Aya trailed off for a moment. “I need to show you something. Introduce you to someone. Stay here for a minute?” Something seemed off with Aya. She seemed... worried. Elyssa had rarely seen Aya like this growing up—whatever this was about, it must be serious. She gave Aya a nod and let her leave the room. A few minutes later, Aya returned, telling someone outside the room to stay there for a moment. Then, she walked in, keeping her eyes averted.

“While I was exploring the house, I found some pieces of a construct’s shell. He felt... familiar. Broken, like me. So I decided to rebuild him. He’s... kind of... like my... my son. He’s been by my side ever since, helping me with... well, everything. I’m sorry I haven’t introduced you yet; I just... didn’t want you to be mad.” Elyssa’s brow furrowed. *Kira and I... we have a grandson?! This is incredible! Why would I be upset about that? Is she scared I’ll think she stole stuff from us to make him? Of course I wouldn’t; this is wonderful news! So what could it be?*

Aya called out to her son. “Dave, you can come in now. Slowly, please.”

Elyssa’s blood froze. Her breath caught in her throat, suffocating her. Her heart pounded so fast, it felt as though it were trying to tear itself from her chest and escape. Around the corner came the unmistakable silhouette of a Clockwork Horror. Elyssa crumbled to her knees, gasping for air, as all

the trauma she had endured over the last eternity came rushing to the forefront of her mind. She couldn't move; she couldn't think. On the edge of her hearing, she thinks she hears her daughter's voice, but she can't be sure. After what felt like hours, Elyssa looked up. There was no Clockwork Horror; Aya was right beside her, arms wrapped around her in a hug, trying to comfort her.

"What... what was that?" Elyssa's words were stretched thin, as though it took all her strength to force them out.

"That was Dave—my son. The chassis he was built around was a spare Horror chassis you and *Amme* had been studying. At the time, I... did not know what the Horrors had done. Aside from his appearance, though, he is entirely my creation. I programmed him and built all his attachments and tools; he is mine. He may not be perfect, but... he is my son. Knowing what I know now, I would probably have made him... appear different—more distinct from the Horrors. But I was alone and he was there. I'm sorry if... seeing him hurts."

Elyssa's breath had begun returning to normal by now. She looked over at her daughter; it was clear how much Dave meant to her.

"Oh, Aya... I'm not upset about Dave. I think it's wonderful that you have a son. I just... *Amme* and I have been through a lot. I'm sure Dave is incredible; anything you set your mind to is sure to work out. But... it's going to be a long road for us to start to recover from what we've been through. It's all so... fresh. It's hard to separate him from the real Horrors, you know?" Aya shook her head in understanding. "It's... probably gonna take some time for us to start to heal. All that time we spent with them... it's all a blur, but at the same time, none of it is. It's still... real." Elyssa pulled her daughter into an even tighter hug.

"Do you think... one day, you'll be able to spend time around him?" Aya's voice quivered while she said it.

"Of course. One day."

"I... had some difficulties with him, when I was making him. Maybe... one day, you and *Amme* could help me? I love him, but he... still needs some improvements."

"Of course, sweetie. One day." Elyssa pulled away from her daughter reluctantly. "Would you be able to get your friends together? Seeing Dave... it reminded me of some things that... they made us work on. It might help you all in your fight against the Horrors."

Aya stood up and shook herself out, preparing to go find her friends. She looked back at Kira, unconscious on the bed, and then Elyssa, still crumpled to her knees on the floor, and steeled her resolve to end this fight.

"Of course."